

SHORT COMMUNICATION

ALTERNATIVE SYSTEM OF MEDICINE, YESTERDAY, TODAY AND TOMORROW

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INTRODUCTION

1. When we talk of yesterday, it is not possible to talk about any system of medicine without mentioning some of the greats of the past. Hippocrates lived during the period 460 – 360 BC. Galen's life was spread from 129 A.D. to 200 A.D., Avicenna lived from 980 to 1037 AD. Their knowledge about medicine was based on observations and the effects of drugs primarily extracted from the plants. Then in 1609 Zacharias Jansen invented the microscope which brought a revolution regarding the causation of the disease. Experiments by Edward Jenner about the control of Small Pox in 1802, Louis Pasteur's (1822-1895) finding about fermentation due to microbes, immunization against rabies, Joseph Lister's (1827-1912) introduction of aseptic surgery, discovery of penicillin in 1940 by Alexander Fleming opened the new chapters about the treatment and control of the diseases. Other inventions in the field of medicine & dissemination of knowledge in the 20th century are so remarkable, current and generally known to the educated people that I don't have to elaborate this point.

2. However, it may be seen that from Hippocrates, addressed in Urdu literature asGalen called asand Avicenna named as to the present day is almost a time distance of 2500 years which I have to cover in a few sentences. Question arises that what is alternative system of medicine? I think in the general sense today

anything which is accepted in any country as a system of repairing a dysfunction of the health may it be homeopathy, Ayurvedic system of medicine or the Greco-Arab medicine which some individuals also call as Islamic medicine, is part of Alternative system of medicine. It will be too much to talk of homeopathy & Ayurvedic system of medicine and Chinese system which may have good points. I shall therefore restrict my views on the Greco-Arab medicine specially the role of plants & herbs.

“Allah Subhana- Tala says” in SURA-E-ANNAHAL“

“68. Your Lord predisposed the bees to make their hives in mountains, trees and trellises. 69. And suck from all the fruits and flit through the trodden paths of their Lord. A drink of various hues comes out of their bellies which contains medicine for men. In this is a sign for those who reflect”.

Ibne Sina listed 800 drugs derived from herbs, I like to mention here only a few which are still in use in the present day modern system of medicine.

a) CINCHONA BARK: Provides an alkaloid from which quinine is extracted. Quinine was once upon a time most commonly used for the treatment of malaria. It is an effective blood schizonticide against all forms of malaria. Today it may be used for cerebral malaria when nothing helps. It will be of interest to

mention that in one of the camps of German prisoners of War in Russia after the 2nd World War, a German medical officer encountered an epidemic of malaria. With very poor living conditions and non-availability of antimalarial drugs the only course open to him was to use the cinchona bark from the trees which were present in the camp. Its use was discontinued due to cinchonism intra vascular hemorrhage and black water fever.

b) CURAE: Once upon a time used by the Red Indians to poison the arrows in order to kill their enemies. It was extracted from the bark and stem of a botanical plant known as *Chondra tomatosum*. It is used for reduction of spasm in tetanus, spastic paralysis and as adjunct to general anaesthetic. It is a neuro muscular blocking agent.

c) DIGITALIS: Is extracted from a plant known as Foxglove (*Digitalis purpurea*). The main systemic effects are manifested by the use in the strength of heart beat while decreasing its rate. It is normally used in the treatment of congestive heart failure.

d) RESERPINE: Is extracted from a plant known *Rauwolfia Serpentina*. It controls mild and moderate hypertension and can also cause sedative action.

e) ARTEMESINE: Is taken from a Chinese herb known as Qing Hao. It has been used in China as an antipyretic for almost 1000 years. It is an effective blood Shizonticide against all types of malaria. The injectable form of this drug indicated apparent superiority for treatment of cerebral and other severe malarial due to their rapid action on fever, parasitaemia and coma.

f) ERGOT: Is a dried sclerotium of *lariceps purpurea* and is utilized as an oxytocic and treatment of migraine.

g) SANTONIN is obtained from the herbs of *Arimise* Wartime which was very commonly used as an antihelmenthic agent.

h) HERBS AGAINST AIDS: In vitro anti-HIV activity has been reported for the following chinese medicinal plants: *Glycyrrhiza uralensis*, *Hypericum perforatum*, *Viola yedoensis*, *Alternanthera philoxeroides*, *Andrographis paniculata*, *Arctium lappa*, *Lithospermum erythrorhizon*, *Coptis chinensis*, *Epimedium grandiflorum*, *Lonicera japonica* and *Prunella vulgaris*.

The protein trichosanthin (compound Q or GLQ 223), isolated from the Chinese herb *Trichosanthes kirilowii*, has been used not only in China as an abortifacient, but also to treat patients with AIDS in unofficial trials in the United States of America. Compound Q has also been approved for limited clinical trial by the United States Food and Drug Administration. It has been reported to interfere with the replication of HIV, and selectively to eliminate infected cells.

i) OPIATES there are number of opiates derived from the poppy plant *Morphine* and *diamorphine* which apart from causing sedation, relief of pain have been used to control cough and diarrheas.

j) HASHISH/CANABIS Hashish grows widely in Pakistan. The flower and small leaves of *cannabis sativa* supply most of the drug. It causes euphoria, alteration of time sense and relaxation. Increased pulse rate and reddening of the conjunctiva are two important signs of its toxicity. Many so called spiritual healers sitting in grave yards and claiming to remain awake at night praying to God are infact consumers of cannabis.

It is an irony of the fate that in the nineteenth century the people of South Asia notably the Chinese were forced to consume the opium. That is how Hongkong was ceded to the British after the treaty of Nanking in 1845. Today, to consume some of the opiates and even hashish for their medicinal effect will be considered as a taboo.

CONCLUSION

Once there is a divine message it should be taken that the role of plants and herbs is established, for all times to come. They do not only give an aesthetic look to our gardens and environment but there lies a secret for cure of many ailments and maladies. Medicine derived from the plants will always find a place in the world. It is a point which is not debatable. The contention that herbal medicines do not cause adverse effects is a statement which needs reconsideration and reevaluation in view of the scientific data available.

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